The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Iran said it was closing the **Strait of Hormuz** again because of America's naval blockade. On Friday Iran had declared the waterway open. But the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, the country's elite paramilitary force, accused America of "failing to meet commitments" and said that any vessel approaching the strait would now be "targeted". The announcement came amid reports that two ships had come under fire from Iranian gunboats.

Donald Trump said **America** would not stand for "blackmail" after Iran's reversal over the Strait of Hormuz. But the president added that "very good conversations" with Iran were continuing. Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf, Iran's top negotiator, said there had been "progress" but "a big distance" remains between the two countries.

North Korea fired several ballistic missiles into its eastern waters. The country has now carried out four such launches this month. South Korea urged its neighbour to "stop the provocative acts". Earlier this week, the International Atomic Energy Agency, the global nuclear watchdog, said North Korea had made "very serious" progress towards building nuclear weapons.

Brazil, **Mexico** and **Spain** issued a joint statement expressing "deep concern" over the "grave humanitarian crisis" in **Cuba**. The island is suffering from fuel shortages and blackouts caused partly by an oil blockade imposed by America. The statement did not mention America by name but called for "sincere and respectful" dialogue. The three countries also pledged to send more aid.

At least six people were killed and several injured after a man opened fire on a street in **Kyiv**, Ukraine's capital, and then took hostages in a supermarket. The gunman, identified by Ukraine's attorney-general as a 58-year-old born in Moscow, was killed after police stormed the shop. His motive remains unclear. Such incidents are rare in Ukraine.

Emmanuel Macron, **France's** president, said that a French member of a UN peacekeeping force had been killed in **Lebanon**, the day after a ceasefire between Israel and Hizbullah began. Mr Macron said evidence suggested that the Iranian-backed militia was responsible for the attack, in which three other soldiers were wounded. Hizbullah denied involvement. Lebanon's prime minister said he had ordered an investigation.

Mr Trump signed an executive order loosening restrictions on **psychedelics** such as LSD, Ecstasy and psilocybin (which is found in magic mushrooms). Mind-altering drugs are being studied for their therapeutic benefits. The order also earmarked $50m for federal research into ibogaine, a substance made from African shrub roots, which might be useful in treating opioid addiction.

Word of the week: "Passport bros", Western men who go abroad to find traditional wives. Read about how frustration with modern dating has fuelled the social-media movement.

Photograph: EPA

South Korea flirts with new partners

Lee Jae Myung, South Korea's president, begins a three-day state visit to India on Sunday. The trip is the first by a South Korean leader in eight years and marks the start of a charm offensive on developing countries. Mr Lee will travel with a delegation of 200 business leaders, including bosses from Samsung, Hyundai and LG. Mr Lee and Narendra Modi, India's prime minister, will hold a summit on AI, defence and shipbuilding.

Mr Lee's courtship of India represents a pivot away from South Korea's deep but strained alliances with America, China and Japan. With the war in Iran disrupting the flow of crude oil, on which South Korea heavily relies, the country is keen to secure new energy supplies and manufacturing hubs. The two countries aim to reach $50bn in bilateral trade by 2030. Known for appearing in slick videos, Mr Lee may draw millions to his TikTok profile, but it is his pragmatism that will be on show this weekend.

Photograph: Getty Images

Bulgaria goes to the polls, again

Bulgarians vote on Sunday in their eighth parliamentary election in five years. Most polls put a former president, Rumen Radev, and his newly formed Progressive Bulgaria party in the lead. Also in the running is Boyko Borissov, a three-time prime minister and former bodyguard, whose ideologically colourless GERB ("coat of arms") party was ousted after anti-government protests in December.

Mr Radev, a former fighter pilot, has pledged to clean up Bulgaria's "mafia state" and to root out oligarchs, who he accuses Mr Borissov's party of being in cahoots with. As president Mr Radev spoke out against the EU's support for Ukraine and the West's sanctions against Russia. And some fear that he could become a new spoiler in Brussels, like Hungary's Viktor Orban, who lost power last week. Still, polls suggest that Mr Radev's party could win 31% of the vote, which would leave him short of a parliamentary majority. The search for coalition partners may force him to compromise.

Photograph: Getty Images

Humanoids race towards the future

More than 300 humanoid robots will compete against humans in a half-marathon in Beijing on Saturday. The event is intended to spur innovation and competition in a sector prized by the state. This week a Chinese firm and industry leader, Unitree, announced it had set a record peak speed of ten metres per second under test conditions, about three times faster than the average human.

Last year's inaugural half-marathon was a smaller affair. Just 21 robots competed, with only six crossing the finish line. Almost all were remotely steered by humans. Technical problems, such as tripping over and overheating, slowed down the race. The stakes were lower, too: the winner took home just 5,000 yuan ($730) in prize money. This year roughly 40% of the starters are likely to be autonomous robots. As well as the race, they will be competing to win guaranteed orders totalling more than 1m yuan. Officials hope the event will show that China is setting the pace in future technologies.

Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Asim Munir, Donald Trump’s favourite field-marshal

Descending from his plane onto the Tehran tarmac on April 15th, Asim Munir looked every inch the military strongman. The mustachioed chief of Pakistan’s army wore fatigues and a black beret and carried a baton, a symbol of his rank as field-marshal. He greeted Iran’s foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, with a salute, followed by a bear hug.

Officially, Field-Marshal Munir has no role in foreign policy. Yet he brokered the temporary ceasefire between Iran and America. On April 11th in Pakistan’s capital he hosted the first meeting between delegations from the two countries in almost 50 years. Now he is engineering a second, perhaps this time including Donald Trump, who has called him his “favourite field-marshal”. Although Pakistan has a civilian government, Field-Marshal Munir is the country’s most powerful person.

Such a career would have seemed improbable back in 2019, when Pakistan’s then prime minister, Imran Khan, removed him from the powerful post of spy chief. But after Mr Khan, a cricketer-turned-populist-superstar, was ousted by the political and military establishment, then-General Munir was brought back into the fold. He was appointed army chief in 2022, and quickly secured his grip on the armed forces by locking up rivals.

His making, however, was a four-day war with India last year. The downing of five Indian jets inspired a wave of Pakistani patriotism. General Munir took advantage, getting himself promoted to the armed forces' highest rank (he is the second person ever to reach it), and ramming through constitutional changes to expand his role and extend his tenure. He is now the most powerful Pakistani leader since Pervez Musharraf, a military officer-turned-dictator who was deposed in 2008.

Field-Marshal Munir is the son of an imam, and the first army chief who can recite the Koran by heart. He is secretive, an unsurprising quality in a former leader of the foreign- and military-intelligence agencies. One of the few journalists to have met him reveals only that he has a firm handshake and smokes Dunhill Blue cigarettes. Less mysterious is his vision for Pakistan, which involves military strength, confronting India and the Afghan Taliban and closer ties with other Muslim powers, from Turkey to Saudi Arabia.

He is sharp, wily, ambitious and ruthless, say those who have watched his rise. But if that has helped to bring success abroad, it has been coupled with deepening repression at home. Mr Khan is in solitary confinement; hundreds more politicians have been jailed and media freedom has been curtailed. "Our generation thought we'd left this behind us," says Mustafa Khokhar, vice-chairman of the opposition alliance. If he achieves more diplomatic success Field-Marshal Munir will become even more powerful at home.

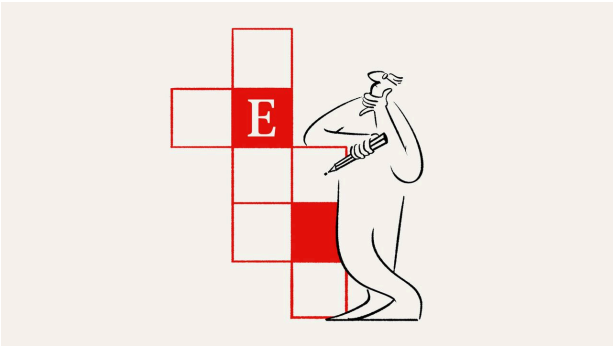

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Stormont sides with global conflict (6)

2 across - Explosive noble prize-giver (5)

3 across - Kevin or Malcolm have ordinary feature (6)

1 down - What learners owe after graduation stunned a lot (7,4)

Straight clues

1 across - Discord, argument (6)

2 across - Inventor of dynamite and founder of coveted prizes (5)

3 across - Usual, conventional (6)

4 across - Money borrowed to pay for university (7,4)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of the week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Jeff Schock, Olympia, Washington, America
John Biggs, Sheffield, Britain
Luis Llanos, Santiago, Chile

They all gave the correct answers of: Ken Burns, Flanders, Maggie Gyllenhaal, the Mona Lisa and Homer. The theme is characters from "The Simpsons": Mr Burns, Ned Flanders, Maggie, Lisa and Homer Simpson.

The questions were:

Monday: Which American film-maker is known for documentary series on the US civil war, baseball and the Vietnam war?

Tuesday: Brussels is the capital of which region in Belgium?

Wednesday: Which American actress and film-maker directed the 2026 movie "The Bride!"?

Thursday: Which famous painting was stolen from the Louvre in 1911 and not returned until 1914?

Friday: Which Greek poet is generally credited as the writer of the Iliad and the Odyssey?

The greatest deception men suffer is from their own opinions

Leonardo da Vinci